

For all the fuss over threats from the Chinese dragon, the fact remains, the dragon is a mythical creature. The elephant exists. Today, there is nothing all that 'incredible' about India. The early 'gee whiz' reaction has been replaced by the more important 'wow factor'. We've done it, dammit. And every Indian who travels overseas can sense this change. Economic muscle power is just one aspect of the new-found respect Indians encounter. And, I'm sorry, but I think it also goes well beyond the stale BPO story. The reason why India rocks is because we have the money to match our guts. And it is guts that are doing it for us. Perhaps for the first time ever, India has been able to stand up and be counted. Gone is the old *chamchagiri* in the presence of G8 leaders, the sickening obsequiousness. From Bush, Brown, Putin, Merkel and now Sarkozy, we have looked them in the eye and said, "Hello, are you talking to me?" like Robert de Niro. Good feeling. New feeling.

Middle India is practically unrecognisable in every which way. People discuss a nebulous cultural and sexual revolution in awestruck terms. It's true, a lot has changed.



But a lot still remains the same. India shocks easily, despite the bravado and big talk. Periodic surveys show the same old prejudices and hangups, never mind that our movies pretend otherwise. Women may be wearing less and less, drinking and smoking much more, sleeping around with abandon, and generally feeling "liberated". But behind all that stylish huffing and puffing, society continues to frown at the "Westernisation" of our youth, and bridegrooms still prefer virgins.

Decade 2000 spells excess. Like Oliver, we all want more. More of everything. India has discovered a new narcotic. It's called 'quality of life'. From a *dhobi* to a DJ, the race is on to acquire all those goodies that used to be unattainable in the

past. Our tycoons have shown the way. The good life is here to stay. From private yachts and jets, to island getaways and stud farms, affluence and luxury dictate tastes across the board. The branding of India is the next big story after biggies like LVMH have tested the waters and declared them easily navigable.

The other significant shift has come from the Millennium Woman. She has claimed her place in the sun, and isn't about to budge an inch. It has been a hard fought battle. Now that the turf is hers, she's staying put. With a mind of her own, and money to match, she has successfully renegotiated the equation with society. You really don't want to mess with this lady. Has this successful city chick's newly-acquired status helped her rural sisters? Not yet, but what else is the trickle down effect for? Personal ambition is driving most of the present change and will continue to do so. Prepare yourself for a decade of unadulterated self-indulgence and self-love, propelled by greed in the Gordon Gecko league. Can the delicate fabric of Indian society handle naked avarice? Will it? Should it? At what cost? Have the

Russian billionaires ever stopped to ask themselves such a question? *Nyet, nyet*. They have cleverly focused on making more roubles. Them. The old Russkies with commie commitments. We're *desis, yaar*. No such hangover.

Despite all the new and old double standards, there is an unmistakable buoyancy in the air. It's a decade of hope and expectancy. Overseas Indians are coming back home in droves, attracted by the magnet of a motherland they may never have known, but feel a part of. This newly-acquired sense of belonging goes hand-in hand with the sense of security India offers its prodigal sons. The very shores they abandoned, now appear more welcoming. The gilt-edged dream they chased by relocating in 'phoren' is no longer all that attractive. Suddenly, *mere desh ki*

*dharti* has become their theme song. Welcome home, strangers. It's all about the money. And the general belief is that the lolly is all here. Financial wizards are only too happy to share their upbeat forecasts and inform non-converts that international big bucks have shifted to India. "It's a great place to park one's money," is one phrase that's repeated ad nauseum by smug 'suits' working the circuit. We hear you, guys. No one I know is complaining.

So does that mean we can put on our dancing shoes? Why not? Who's to stop us now?

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